

STUNNING SAIL

DIMETRODON

Although at first glance it looks like a dinosaur, this prehistoric animal was actually a different type of creature called a synapsid, which is more closely related to mammals. It appeared during the Permian Period, some 60 million years before the first dinosaurs, and may have been one of Earth's first large land predators. Fossils of different *Dimetrodon* species tell us that it was a fearsome carnivore. Its serrated teeth would have allowed it to easily slice through the skin and flesh of its prey. Scientists are unsure about the use of *Dimetrodon*'s sail, but most think that it may have been used for display when competing for mates.

**LARGEST
SAIL: SYNAPSID**

Dimetrodon's tail was made up of more than 50 bones.

Dimetrodon's short legs meant it was probably only capable of brief bursts of speed.

STATS AND FACTS

Dimetrodon had heterodont teeth, which means that its teeth had different shapes depending on their position in the mouth. This is unlike the teeth of most reptiles but is similar to those of modern-day mammals.

WEIGHT



The largest *Dimetrodon* species probably weighed around 550 lb (250 kg), similar to a Bengal tiger.

SKULL SIZE



The biggest *Dimetrodon* skull ever found measures about 19½ in (50 cm) in length.

SAIL HEIGHT

5 FT
(1.5 M)

